RELATIONSHIPS & INFERENCE

Cause and Effect - Workbook 2

Practice implied causes and situations with more than one possible explanation.

Strategy reminder	Write the relationship as CAUSE -> EFFECT. Then ask whether the passage proves the link or only suggests it. Notice other factors that may also explain the result.

Checkout Form

Text 1	An online store reduced its checkout form from four pages to two. In the same week, it also began offering free shipping on orders above $25. The number of completed purchases increased. A manager argued that the shorter form caused the increase, but the analytics team said the test could not separate the effect of the form from the new shipping offer.

1. Why can the team not conclude that the shorter form alone caused the increase?

A. No purchases were completed

B. Free shipping was introduced at the same time

C. The form became longer

D. The manager removed the shipping offer

2. Which claim is best supported?

A. The shorter form definitely had no effect

B. Free shipping definitely caused every additional purchase

C. One or both changes may have contributed to the increase

D. The increase proves customers dislike free shipping

Wetland Restoration

Text 2	A park restored a wetland by reopening a blocked channel in early spring. By summer, water remained in the wetland longer after storms and more frogs were counted. That spring was also wetter than average. The park report states that the restored channel likely improved water retention but that rainfall probably contributed to the higher water levels as well.

3. Which factor does the report say likely contributed to longer water retention?

A. The reopened channel

B. A decrease in rainfall

C. Fewer frogs

D. Closing the channel again

4. Why does the report mention the wetter-than-average spring?

A. To prove the restoration failed

B. To identify another factor that may have affected water levels

C. To show rainfall never affects wetlands

D. To explain why the channel was blocked

Flexible Start Times

Text 3	A company allowed employees to start work between 7:30 and 9:30 instead of requiring everyone to arrive at 8:30. Parking-lot congestion fell during the first month. At the same time, the building opened a second parking entrance. A staff survey showed that many employees had shifted their arrival times, but it did not measure how much the new entrance affected traffic.

5. Which conclusion about the drop in congestion is best supported?

A. Flexible start times were definitely the only cause

B. The second entrance was definitely the only cause

C. Flexible arrival times may have helped, but the new entrance is another possible cause

D. Congestion fell before either change

6. Which detail most directly supports the idea that flexible start times could have helped?

A. Many employees shifted their arrival times

B. The building has a parking lot

C. The company completed a survey

D. Employees work in the building

Review your reasoning

Before checking the key, mark the question that felt hardest. Write one clue that changed your mind and name the distractor that was most tempting.

Answer key and reasoning

1. B - A second change could also have influenced completed purchases.
Watch for: When two possible causes change together, the passage may support only a cautious conclusion.

2. C - The data show an increase after both changes, but do not isolate either one.
Watch for: Avoid claims stronger than the evidence.

3. A - The report explicitly says the restored channel likely improved water retention.
Watch for: "Likely" signals a supported but cautious causal claim.

4. B - Rainfall is a competing/contributing explanation for the observed water levels.
Watch for: Good causal reasoning notices alternative factors.

5. C - Two relevant changes occurred, so the evidence does not isolate one cause.
Watch for: Use cautious language when the text includes a confounding factor.

6. A - Staggered arrival times provide a mechanism for reducing congestion at one peak time.
Watch for: Choose evidence that explains how the proposed cause could produce the effect.